

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Trump dogged by self-made mess

After years hyping Epstein ‘secrets,’ his base demands more

By Ali Swenson and Nicholas Riccardi
Associated Press

NEW YORK — As his supporters erupt over the Justice Department’s failure to release much-hyped records in Jeffrey Epstein’s sex trafficking investigation, President Donald Trump’s

strategy has been to downplay the issue.

His problem? That nothing-to-see-here approach doesn’t work for those who have learned from him that they must not give up until the government’s deepest, darkest secrets are exposed. Last week, the Justice Depart-

ment and the FBI abruptly walked back the notion that there’s an Epstein client list of elites who participated in the wealthy New York financier’s trafficking of underage girls. Trump quickly defended Attorney General Pam Bondi and chided a reporter for daring to ask about the documents. The online reaction was swift,

with followers calling the Republican president “out of touch” and demanding transparency.

On Saturday, Trump used his Truth Social platform to again attempt to call supporters off the Epstein trail amid reports of infighting between Bondi and FBI Deputy Director Dan Bongino over the issue. He suggested the turmoil was undermining his administration — “all over a guy who never dies, Jeffrey Epstein.”

The political crisis is challenging for Trump because it’s one of his own making. The president has spent years stoking dark theories and embracing QAnon-tinged propaganda that casts him as the only savior who can demolish the “deep state.”

Now that he’s running the federal government, the community he helped build is coming back

Turn to Trump, Page 5

Ill. public radio, TV fear cuts to funding

Impacts to Chicago’s WBEZ and WTTW, downstate stations

By Daniel C. Vock
Chicago Tribune

WASHINGTON — The GOP-controlled Senate is expected to decide this week whether to slash federal spending on public radio and TV, a move national Republicans say is long overdue but Illinois Democrats and media advocates argue could deprive Americans of reliable sources for news and educational programming.

Chicago’s public media outlets — WBEZ and WTTW — will undoubtedly get hit by the President Donald Trump-endorsed plan to take away \$1.1 billion from the Corporation for Public Broadcasting over the next two years. But the cuts would have a far greater impact on smaller stations that rely more on federal funding and predominantly serve rural areas.

The coming Capitol Hill debate follows years of complaining by Republicans who claim that National Public Radio and the Public Broadcasting Service are biased against conservatives. Until now, those criticisms weren’t enough to convince lawmakers to make significant cuts to public broadcasting funding. But those efforts found new life with the second-term presidency of Trump, who has made media criticism a cornerstone of his political career and is now championing the budget cuts to 1,500 public media outlets across the country.

Turn to Cuts, Page 2

‘Granny flats’ closer to citywide legalization

Chicago aldermen advanced a measure that could legalize “granny flats” citywide with limited restrictions, a move advocates say will create more affordable housing. Page 4

Inflation worsens as tariffs take hold

Inflation rose last month to its highest level since February as President Donald Trump’s sweeping tariffs push up the cost of a range of goods. Business, page 2

The next-gen MLB All-Stars

Paul Sullivan: With Pete Crow-Armstrong, Jacob Wilson and “The Miz,” baseball’s future is in good hands. Chicago Sports



TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Trial begins for man charged in 2023 fatal shooting of officer

Rocio Lasso, center, the mother of slain Chicago police Officer Andrés Mauricio Vásquez Lasso, walks through the lobby of the Leighton Criminal Court Building in Chicago on Tuesday during a break in the trial of his accused killer, Steven Montano. Chicagoland, Page 3



A firefly caught by Beatriz Swanson crawls inside an observation jar during an educational program about fireflies at the Hidden Oaks Nature Center in Bolingbrook on Friday. JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Swarms of fireflies in Illinois give enthusiasts hope insect can survive

By Kate Perez

Beatriz Swanson can remember the first time she saw the blinking glow. She was 10 years old, growing up in Mexico, when two fireflies appeared in front of her, floating away before she could carefully capture them in her hands.

Swanson did not see the shining insects again until she moved to upstate New York 17 years after her first encounter. Riding

in a car at dusk, a cloud of fireflies caught her eye, still holding their allure after all those years.

“I couldn’t believe how many we saw,” Swanson said. “I told my husband to stop. I was like a child watching. I was in such awe seeing such beauty. So since then, I’ve loved them.”

Now a Plainfield resident, Swanson, 51, joined over a dozen other insect fans on a recent hike in Bolingbrook, where she caught two fireflies in a jar,

watching them blink back and forth briefly, before she set them free.

Many people across the U.S. share Swanson’s sentiment for fireflies, which are classified as beetles. Reports of fewer fireflies in recent years have sparked worry for the future of the insect’s population. However, increased sightings this summer have boosted hopes for the

Turn to Firefly, Page 4

Speculation Mendoza may mount mayoral bid

Illinois comptroller may skip running for 4th term, sources say

By Rick Pearson and Jeremy Gerner
Chicago Tribune

As Cook County Democrats prepare to gather later this week to endorse candidates for the 2026 primary election, there is growing speculation Illinois Comptroller Susana Mendoza will skip running for reelection so she can mount a possible 2027 bid for Chicago mayor.

Several Democratic sources said Mendoza has told them she will not run for a fourth term as the state’s chief fiscal control officer, an office she won in a special midterm election in 2016. The sources requested confidentiality to avoid jeopardizing their relationships within the state Democratic Party.

In addition, Mendoza did not meet last week’s deadline set by Cook County Democratic Party officials to confirm an appearance at this Friday’s county slating to formally seek the endorsements of Demo-

Turn to Mendoza, Page 6

